

economies that complement the India growth story.

We are not in competition. We can truly help each other, provide opportunities for their investments to work in India and capture world markets leveraging the innovation and technologies that they have and providing jobs to Indians.

Q: In the Prime Minister's first term and to some extent in the second term, the feeling was that India was pushing for *Swadeshi*, which was translated as protectionism. Did you face resistance from within while negotiating these deals?

A: I have no issue whatsoever, and I say this with full confidence because you wouldn't have heard one criticism, one negative edit about the first eight deals that we struck. I assure you they will not be able to pick one hole in the US deal either, because we have not compromised on any of our national interests in any of the deals.

For example, dairy has not been opened in any FTA. By the way, Switzerland, the EU, UK, Australia, New Zealand, they've never struck free trade deals with their dairy. We are the first. We were confident that we would be able to explain to them that we cannot compromise on the interests of our small farmers; they can't compete with the organised dairy of the developed world.

Thanks to that plain-speaking approach, countries today trust Prime Minister Modi to give them a fair deal and they recognise that India is a trusted partner. Our idea is to capture the low-hanging fruit and not make the perfect the enemy of the good; look for commonalities, I respect their sensitivities, they respect ours.

Q: The concern is that we have compromised on agricultural products like soyabean.

A: We have not compromised on soyabean. We are one of the largest importers in the world of soyabean oil, and we have only given a quota there. But we have not opened the market for soyabean. Wherever there are sensitivities, there is no opening up.

Q: So, you are saying we have made no compromise on agriculture?

A: Absolutely not. It is a win-win. There are areas where we need to import, like fruits that we import from America. Giving a concession there is a zero-sum game. It only helps to get better quality apples than the ones we get from Turkey, for example. So, our ap-

proach is we welcome certain things that India needs, whether it is agriculture, industrial goods, ICT, or technology.

Q: Not on maize as well, as they were looking for?

A: No, there is absolutely no compromise on maize; absolutely no compromise on dairy; absolutely no compromise on GM products; absolutely no compromise on cereals like rice and wheat; absolutely no compromise on sugar; absolutely no compromise on a variety of products that are often found to be sensitive in the Indian context. It's absolutely a win-win for India.

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Q: Why was India willing to make permanent tariff concessions in exchange for what Washington itself describes as conditional and reversible relief?

A: There are two things to note here. First, we have not removed tariffs on all industrial goods to zero. Some are calibrated over time, some are quotas, where we have no sensitivity and need them, like NVIDIA chips or products in AI, quantum computing. It's a very calibrated, well-thought approach from item to item.

Second, the reciprocal tariffs are real. The whole world has acknowledged that. The whole world has negotiated against reciprocal tariffs. So have we. Yet, we have agreed with the US that should the reciprocal tariffs be taken off for everybody, then we would have an opportunity to recalibrate our concessions also, or we would have an opportunity to get further concessions from the US.

So, it's not as if India has removed the MFN (most-favoured-nation) tariffs against a reciprocal tariff that is temporary. If there is a change in reciprocal